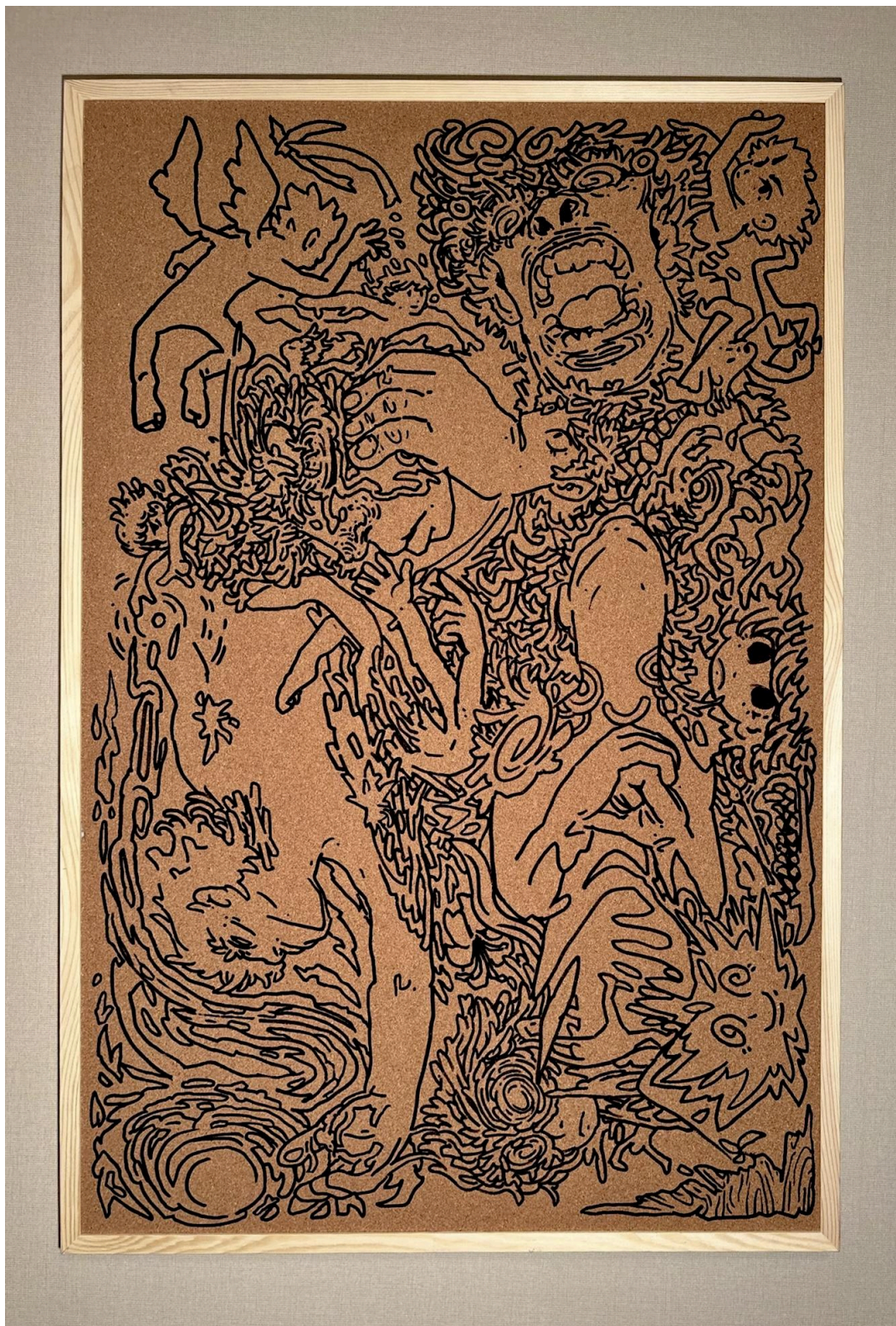




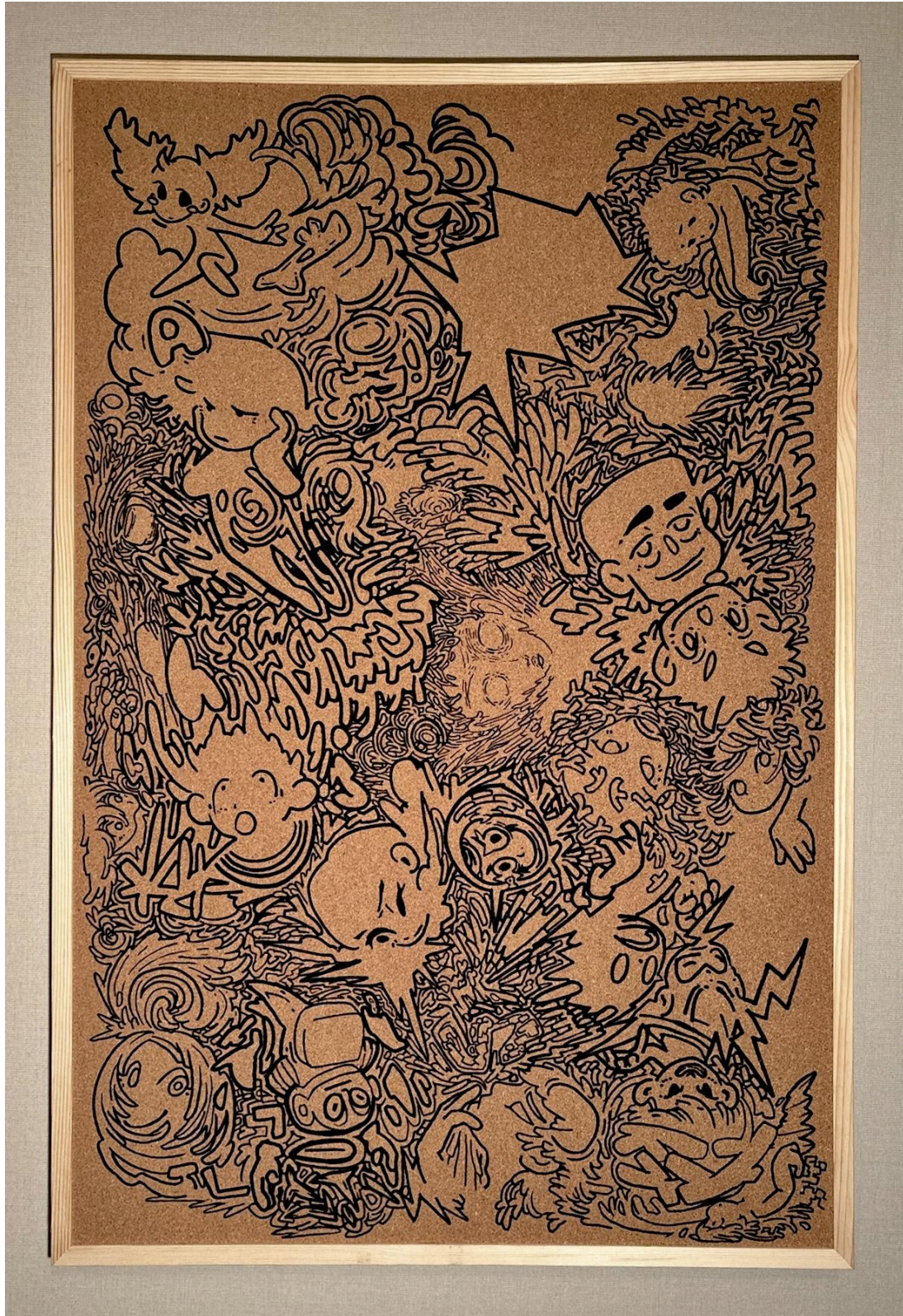
Panel 1: *Stretching time to be on time*



Panel 2: *Materiality in sound*



Panel 3: *Scale of emotion*



Panel 4: *Resolution in speech*

Reiji Shimane

Linguistic Characters, 2024

Exhibited at *Bokuno Sukina Hitoten (Dear People I Love)* at Den Gallery, Tokyo, Japan, July 23-28, 2024
60 x 90 cm.

Ink on four cork panels

“In the digital age, renovate the limit of language. Ignite your words, be part of a big conversation, collect your artifacts, and believe in your intuition of desire in motion to listen to the best version of your world.”

-Reiji Shimane

Exhibited at Reiji Shimane’s first solo exhibition in his home city of Tokyo, *Linguistic Characters* is a work in four parts: *Stretching time to be on time*, *Materiality in sound*, *Scale of emotion*, and *Resolution in speech*. The title of the work encapsulates the dual nature of the figures on the panels as not only characters in a narrative, but also characters of the artist’s alphabet, acting as the semantic foundation for his visual discussion. By utilizing cork as the medium, a material that is both functional and familiar, Shimane relinquishes ownership of this language and establishes approachable entry points of conversation, inviting viewers to touch, challenge, and use his *artput*.

Shimane defines artput as a language for processing input and output, placing emphasis on a structure that rejects the binary evaluation of digital correctness in favor of an appraisal of intensity and passion. *Linguistic Characters* is an archive of his own artput, a guide for those seeking deeper intention in their lives, and an example of the accessibility of expressive freedom that he envisions for a new digital age.

Panel 1: *Stretching time to be on time*

The dynamic movement of *Stretching time to be on time* captures a slowed frame of curiosity and concentration. This panel is the first step in artput, where one finds uncontainable excitement in knowledge, experience, and other vehicles of input that sustain deep intent. With bold expressions and transcendent figures, each iteration of close examination through the whirlwind of energy rewards a sensory experience that renders the audience into the very experience that is illustrated by the unwavering lines. Focus is not limited to a singular main character or starting point, instead being freely determined by the level of imagination that is indulged into the viewing experience. This plurality in perspective is a common style in Shimane’s works, an invitation for creativity in active observation.

Panel 2: *Materiality in sound*

Materiality in Sound draws motifs from Shimane’s time as an artist living in the Harlem neighborhood of New York City, where he experienced firsthand the dense patchwork of cultures separated by mere steps.

The panel is a vigorous map of unique characters, each distinctly contributing in a singular symphony of visual and auditory resonance. Unlike *Stretching time to be on time*, which dwells in the intensity of contemplation, this piece explodes outward, expanding the canvas and challenging the viewer to grasp the interconnectedness of individuals, communities, and industries. With this bustling structure, Shimane emphasizes the second step in his concept of artput: becoming an active curator in the overwhelming entropy of information, and creating a confident sense of identity based on a strong standard of quality.

Panel 3: *Scale of Emotion*

Scale of Emotion introduces a softer, more fluid visual language, where circular lines dominate, and the sharpness of previous works gives way to a harmonious consistency in line width and style. While the previous panels stress discovery based on individual interpretation, this third stage of artput progresses to the need for objective quality in presentation in order for a true linguistic system to be fully established. Although language can exist as an internal tool to understand the self, real experience occurs only when it is shared, argued, and felt in conversation.

Thus, the three foundational pillars for strong artput are established: depth in curiosity, curation in input, and conversation in quality output.

Panel 4: *Resolution in speech*

As the final panel of the quartet, *Resolution in speech* provides insight to Shimane's vision of the digital world as a potential vehicle for artput. Despite his criticism of the current internet's superficiality in conversation and information, he firmly believes in its power to become a form of artput when people recognize and utilize it as a tool capable of holding deep intent, rather than simple entertainment. While *Materiality in sound* was a trial for the audience to partake in active viewership, *Resolution in Speech* is an example of the intentional archive that proves the quality of a linguistic structure. Aspects of the previous panels are present as input in this ultimate piece, from the varying line thickness to the wide spectrum of characters, but they are presented with an additional layer of curated aesthetic that exudes an intuitive stability. Ultimately, Shimane argues that it is this layer of personal language that expands the scale of the perceived world, rejecting blind acceptance of presented information as objective truth. As he states: "Simply put, all we need is to listen and speak better, digitally, with our correct desires. The scale of our objective interpretation is what we are training on the Internet."